

Three quick-win candidates for community banks

Concrete, low-risk, AI-assistable tasks where the time savings are obvious.

The wrong first AI project is a customer-facing chatbot. The right first AI project is something boring, internal, and high-volume that nobody on your staff actually enjoys doing.

Three candidates that meet that bar.

Candidate 1 — Meeting summaries

Most committee meetings produce minutes that nobody reads. AI transcription + summarization can compress a 90-minute ALCO or credit committee into a one-page action register in five minutes. No customer data is involved. The output is reviewed by an attendee before it circulates.

Time saved per meeting: ~60 minutes for the secretary. Multiply by your committee count.

Candidate 2 — Internal policy and procedure search

Every community bank has a 200-page policy manual that staff cannot search effectively. A retrieval-augmented assistant trained on your own policy corpus answers "what is our wire transfer limit for new customers" in seconds, with the source paragraph cited.

This is the most defensible "AI for banking" use case the AI Playbook (Cornerstone, 2025) names. PII never leaves your environment.

Time saved per query: 5–10 minutes per staff lookup. Multiply by hundreds of lookups per month.

Candidate 3 — Variance narrative drafting

The 5-day-close finance team writes the same kind of paragraph every month: "non-interest expense up 3% driven by..." A drafted-by-AI, edited-by-finance variance narrative cuts this from hours to minutes, and the data never leaves a board-internal context.

Time saved per close: 4–8 hours for the finance lead.

Three things you can do this week

- 1. Pick one of these three.** Not all three. One.
- 2. Find the one staffer who already complains about that task most.** Ask them to be the pilot.
- 3. Time the current process before you change anything.** A baseline you can quote later is worth more than a forecast.

A starter prompt

I am looking for our institution's first AI project. The candidates I am evaluating: meeting summaries, policy search, and variance narrative drafting. Which of the three would save the most staff time at our institution this quarter, given how my team currently spends their hours?

Citations

- AI Playbook for Banks and Credit Unions, Cornerstone Advisors, 2025
- FDIC Quarterly Banking Profile — efficiency ratio context, Q4 2024